

The Cartographic Evolution of Baja California

Michael McInnis

Early navigational charts produced from expeditions to the Pacific Coast of North America were surprisingly accurate but over the following one hundred years the cartographic depiction of Baja California was thrown into a state of complete disarray. There were many varied reasons this occurred, but no single event can be identified conclusively as the definitive cause. We will take a short tour of the key events surrounding the greatest case of cartographic divergence in mapping history.

In 1533 Hernán Cortés was using a number of ships to explore new routes to the far east though he was not part of the initial expedition. The earliest explorer to Baja California from this expedition was a mutineer by the name of Fortún Ximénez, the pilot and navigator of the Ship Concepción, who took control of one of Cortés's ships after he led a mutiny against the captain Diego de Becerra. Upon arriving at La Paz Bay, Ximénez himself was killed in an armed conflict with the local population of La Paz. This may be the mythical story associated with the Cerro de la Calavera (Hill of the Skull) which is a prominent point on the north side of La Paz many people hike up for the view and unusual rock formations. Legend has it a local leader and a Spanish explorer clashed on the hill fighting over a beautiful woman and fell to their deaths. The hill resembles a skull from a distance.

The initial expeditions generated talk of oyster beds filled with pearls and rumors of gold and silver which got the attention of Cortés who launched his own personal expedition in 1535. He arrived in La Paz which he initially named Bahía de Santa Cruz on May 3, 1535. The pearls were actually abundant in La Paz Bay and fueled the largest source of pearls worldwide for decades until overharvesting killed the industry.

This initial attempt at establishing a permanent settlement in La Paz was a complete failure due to water shortages, resistance from the local population and crop failures due to the harsh desert conditions that still exist today on the Baja Peninsula. La Paz became a common base of operations for further exploration and an expedition in 1539 led by Francisco de Ulloa firmly established that the Baja Peninsula was not an island.

Unfortunately, none of the original charts of Baja California produced from the Francisco de Ulloa (1539) or Hernando de Alarcón (1540) ventures up the Gulf of California and around the Pacific side of the Baja survive today but a version compiled in 1541 by Domingo del Castillo was of very high quality. Castillo was on both the Ulloa trip and the following Alarcón trip and used notes from Ulloa and his own nautical measurements to produce an amazing chart not published until 1770. Incidentally, this map clearly shows evidence of Alarcón's venture up the Colorado River in a failed attempt to meet up with Francisco Vázquez de Coronado.

The name California has a very convoluted etymology. Cortés named Baja California after a fantastic place from a fictional novel called 'Las Sergas de Esplandián' written by Garci Rodríguez de Montalvo in Spain around 1510. California was the Atlantis of its day in the Spanish consciousness. It was an island far to the west ruled by a Queen Calafia populated with warrior women and rich with gold. The name Calafia is widely used in La Paz today. Many of the early Spanish explorers assumed the Baja was an island and ascribed many of the elements from the fantasy book to the newly discovered 'island'. This gave momentum to the misconception that Baja was an island as opposed to a peninsula as reported by Francisco de Ulloa.

Hernando de Alarcón was following the Colorado River north out of the Gulf of California in a vain attempt to resupply Francisco Vázquez de Coronado who was on a quest to find the The Seven Cities of Cíbola. Like the search for the clearly imaginary land of California or the famed South American 'Empire of El Dorado' which started out as a description of the local Colombian leader covering himself in gold flakes and progressed first into a City of Gold and then a Golden Empire, The Seven Cities of Cibola was another myth being pursued by Spanish explorers.

The myth of The Seven Cities of Cibola: The story goes that seven Christian Bishops fled Spain out into the Atlantic Ocean fleeing the Muslim Conquest of the 8th Century. It goes on to say the seven bishops founded seven wealthy cities beyond the known world. The cities in the west were reputedly filled with silver and gold and turquoise which was rather prophetic. During the 'gold rush' of the Spanish exploration of the Americas many of the explorers thought these mythical cities were real and would be found in Northern Mexico.

So, this all brings us to the cartographic divergence of the early 1600's. Antonio de Herrera y Tordesias seems to have produced the first map of Baja as an island (1622) which was ironic following his original map of Baja as a peninsula (1601). The island map mysteriously showed up on an illustration with no comments regarding why he changed his portrayal and was apparently picked up by subsequent works. Herrera y Tordesias was not an explorer himself but an official of the Spanish government tasked with creating the official, government approved, map of the world.

Why Antonio de Herrera y Tordesias revised his beautiful original map of Baja California in 1622 to show it as an island in the graphic above will probably never be known. Speculation existed that it was done to throw off the claims of other countries or was driven forward by an incomplete west coast survey by Sebastián Vizcaíno which terminated at Monterrey Bay, California and allowed cartographers to speculate there might be a connection to the Gulf of California north of that survey. Following the first depiction of Baja California as an island by Antonio de Herrera y Tordesias it became the dominant land form comprising more than half the examples subsequently published.

What had started out as a very early knowledge that Baja California was a peninsula terminating in the north at the mouth of the Colorado River had diverged into multiple maps depicting the Baja as an island. Whether it was the sheer size of Baja California not allowing an easy determination of its extent or a fantastic myth of a fabulously wealthy land of California populated by a queen and her powerful female army protecting a kingdom of gold and silver and precious metals there seemed to be a built in bias toward the island case. Another common explanation was a west coast survey by Sebastián Vizcaíno which reopened the island/peninsula question with his 1602 map of the west coast that stopped at about Monterrey Bay, California allowing cartographers to speculate that the Gulf of California connected to the ocean somewhere to the north.

The people driven to explore the new world from Spain were captivated with these mythical stories of unlimited wealth and the narrative of a promised island in the west ultimately won out persisting from 1622 until the final main stream map of Baja California as an island is published in 1740 by Matthaus Seutter.

In the same way that Antonio de Herrera y Tordesias flipped from a peninsula map of Baja California to an island map between 1601 and 1622 the inverse could be characterized by Father Eusebio Kino flipping from an island map back to the correct depiction as a peninsula between 1695 and 1721. Father Eusebio Kino arrived at this conclusion after extensive exploration on his own of the wider Northern Mexico, Arizona and California region.

Whether this discrepancy was wishful thinking, an honest mistake or one of the first examples of a cartographic canary trap, it was truly remarkable in its prevalence and longevity. Following are a couple of exquisite early examples of the peninsula and island maps.

1598	Abraham Ortelius	1626	John Speed
			